BOOKS

Charismatic Cat

Peppered with stunning illustrations, *Caracal: An Intimate History of a Mysterious Cat* is a deeply moving and meticulously researched account of the elusive felid



CARACAL:
An Intimate History of a Mysterious Cat
by Dharmendra Khandal and Ishan Dhar
TIGER WATCH
₹3,850; 339 pages

Plenty of coffee-table books have been published on tigers, so it's a pleasant change to have a lavishly illustrated volume dedicated to a lesser-known creature. The caracal is one of the most widely distributed felids on earth, ranging from Africa through the Middle East and further on into South Asia, but it is also the most elusive of cats. Dharmendra Khandal and Ishan Dhar have produced an exhaustive and passionate tribute to a species that is seldom seen yet captures the imagination of every naturalist. Commonly known as the *siyahgosh*, which means black ears in Farsi, this secretive creature has an evolutionary history that is eight million years older than man.

While larger predators like the tiger, lion or leopard capture the spotlight, there is an urgent need to focus on wildlife that can be equally charismatic, if only their stories are told

If there is any predator in India that deserves to be protected, it is the caracal. Its primary habitat is dry deciduous forests and grasslands, most of which have been denuded. It feeds on peacocks and hares, as well as other small mammals, birds and reptiles that cross its path. One of the fascinating episodes in this book is the story of a family of caracals in Ranthambore Tiger Reserve that kill and eat a monitor lizard.

The relocation of African cheetahs to Kuno Palpur National Park in Madhya Pradesh has attracted frenetic media attention over the past two years. If only the money and resources expended on this alien sub-species had been spent on protecting the caracal's natural habitat, we might be closer to saving one of India's critically endangered wild cats instead of providing refugee status for an exotic import that can never replace the Asiatic cheetah, which became extinct here more than a half century ago.

With its distinctly black-tufted ears and narrowed eyes that project a penetrative gaze, the caracal is a beautiful beast, even if its pelage is a dull, dusky tan. Like the cheetah, it was once used